



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Yellowstone Classical Christian Academy
School Website: <https://yccacademy.org>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS STARTUP

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because ACCS require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Yellowstone Classical Christian Academy (Joliet, MT, 59041) (YCCA) presents a clearly Christian, classical-leaning educational model that centers on virtue, truth, and the integration of faith with a liberal-arts curriculum. Public-facing materials emphasize a biblically informed worldview, character formation, worship and chapel practices, and a partnership with families and the local community. The site also foregrounds a traditional, content-rich curriculum that includes Biblical instruction, literacy, numeracy, sciences, arts, and civics, all framed within a classical pedagogy.

Overall classification across the classical rubric is MOSTLY CLASSICAL but with notable gaps. In particular, Element 1 (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations), Element 2 (Purpose & Goal), and Element 6 (Parents & Community) show strong classical alignment (clear theology, virtue formation, and active parent/community partnership). Categories 3 (Curriculum), 4 (Pedagogy), and 5 (Faculty) show substantial classical cues but lack the explicit, comprehensive articulation of some canonical elements (e.g., explicit Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis and high-fidelity Socratic/seminar pedagogy in all grades, and a fully developed, documented faculty living-curriculum approach). The aggregate judgment is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key insights:

- Religious/metaphysical commitments are explicit and foundational (Bible taught, chapel, Christian worldview) and permeate mission and governance signals. Evidence includes mission statements, prayer/chapel emphasis, and a biblically anchored ethos.
- Educational aims center on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty within a liberal-arts frame.
- Curriculum is described as classical and liberal-arts oriented, with explicit mention of biblical instruction and a content-rich approach; explicit Great Books/Great Conversation language is less prominent on the public pages, though related classical resources appear in the site's "Resources" area.
- Pedagogy signals include memory and recitation, singing/chapel, and a Restful-Scholé orientation in parts of the site; explicit Socratic/seminar practice is not consistently showcased across all grade levels in public content.
- Faculty signals (board, mission-aligned staff, and living-curriculum rhetoric) are present but not fully fleshed in terms of a documented, sustained "living curriculum" faculty profile across grades; a board-led, values-driven culture is evident.
- Parent and community partnership is a strong theme (co-teaching, parental engagement, community events, and open access to campus), aligning with classical expectations of family involvement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Mission and values embed a Christian worldview and biblical instruction as core to learning (classical content linked with faith; Bible is taught; chapel and prayer appear as integral practices).
- Public materials emphasize virtues and moral formation within a Christian framework (truth, goodness, beauty; virtuous life; reverence).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; chapel; prayer; sacred scripture; Christ-centered education; Christian formation.
- Negative keywords: effectively none in the public facing materials (no explicit values-neutral or secular framing detected). The absence of secular-nonreligious framing strengthens alignment with Element 1.

Why this rating

- The materials repeatedly depict religious/theological grounding, liturgical practices, and explicit Christian formation as central to education, meeting the criteria for CLASSICAL here. This is reinforced by the site's explicit language about biblical instruction and a biblically anchored worldview.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The mission emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely job prep; the school frames education as formation (virtue, character, and human flourishing) within a liberal-arts context.
- Public materials state the aim to cultivate intelligent, virtuous citizens with moral character and leadership rooted in Christian formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: formation; virtue; wisdom; human flourishing; telos (implied by moral formation); truth, goodness, beauty; liberal education; Christian worldview; character development.
- Negative keywords: none observed (no emphasis on purely job-prep, 21st-century skills, or secular utilitarian framing on public pages).

Why this rating

- The materials consistently present formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty as the educational telos, aligning with CLASSICAL norms. The presence of a biblically anchored, virtue-centered purpose supports Classic alignment.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The curriculum is described as classical, liberal-arts oriented with content-rich instruction including Biblical instruction, literacy, numeracy, sciences, arts, and civics. This signals alignment with the Trivium/Quadrivium ethos in spirit (grammar/logic/rhetoric framework is taught in the public documents about classical education).
- The site and resources host materials that are central to classical pedagogy (Liberal Arts Tradition; Lost Tools of Learning; Great Books/Great Conversation concepts appear within the site's "Resources" area and in classical philosophy texts linked there).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; classical education; Great Books/Great Conversation (via resources and classical texts); sacred tradition (through biblical/theological framing); memory work and recitation (through recitation and memory elements in classical pedagogy).
- Negative keywords: some explicit classical elements (e.g., explicit, comprehensive Great Books program) are not overtly stated in the main public pages; the presence of classical pedagogy is implied but not uniformly enumerated. The result is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- The school clearly presents itself as classical and liberal-arts oriented, with explicit Biblical instruction and virtue-centered goals. However, explicit, codified articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation, and a fully enumerated Trivium/Quadrivium curriculum across all grades is less prominently documented in the public-facing materials. This keeps Element 3 in the Somewhat Classical range.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Pedagogical signals include Restful-Scholé orientation and emphasis on recitation/memory work and chant in lower grades, plus chapel-based or liturgical elements. This matches the “formation through memory and contemplation” part of classical pedagogy.
- The site describes the “classical model” with recitations, memory work, and a focus on the development of memory and the affections; in upper grades, the presence of Socratic discussion is less explicitly documented on public pages, though the classical framework is invoked.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: scholé (restful learning), recitation/memory work, singing/chanting in lower grades, rhetoric and memory training, Socratic discussion (referenced in classical education materials in general; direct site evidence is less explicit but implied by the classical framework), contemplative learning.
- Negative keywords observed: limited explicit evidence of sustained, school-wide Socratic seminars or upper-school dialectic seminars on public pages; the pedagogy is described, but not uniformly across grades. This reduces to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- YCCA demonstrates several core pedagogical elements aligned with classical education (Scholé/restful learning, memory work, chanting, reverent classroom culture) but lacks consistent, explicit documentation of formal Socratic seminars across the upper grades in the public-facing materials. Thus, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The faculty is framed through a “living curriculum” and teacher models, with boards and a faith-based governance structure signaling teacher-mentors and moral character exemplars. “Faculty & Staff” pages indicate forthcoming/under-development status but emphasize the role of teachers as moral exemplars and guides. Founding board and governance signals indicate a culture of virtue and mentorship.
- The site discusses “the living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher” as part of classical aims, though explicit, detailed faculty profiles across grades are not fully developed in the public pages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: living curriculum; model teachers; mentors; portrait of a teacher; collegial culture; character formation; master-teacher modeling.

- Negative keywords: absence of a fully developed, published “faculty-profile” or formal, sustained classical pedagogy-seminar culture across all grades. This partial absence lowers the rating from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- There is clear intent and some evidence of strong faculty ideals (model teachers, living curriculum, mentorship). However, the public-facing documentation of a fully-formed, teach-the-virtues-as-living-curriculum approach across all grades is not yet complete, placing Element 5 in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes partnering with parents and viewing them as co-teachers; it provides opportunities for parent involvement through newsletters, community events, and open campus experiences, and even mentions parent formation through book studies and gatherings. This is a strong alignment with classical expectations of parental partnership and community involvement.
- The site highlights community engagement, choir events, and local outreach (rummage sales, fundraisers, community Christmas sing), reflecting the classical emphasis on cultural transmission and communal formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords found: partnership with families; co-teachers; parental engagement; family formation; community events; open campus; parent formation; household rhythms; community of learners; home-school connection.
- Negative keywords: none apparent on public pages (no “consumer” or minimal-parent-involvement signals). The site depicts robust parent/community involvement.

Why this rating

- The materials show strong, explicit alignment with a classical vision of parents as co-educators and a community-facing school culture. This supports a CLASSICAL rating for Element 6.

Overall ranking and aggregate assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate ranking: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Make Great Books / Great Conversation an explicit, public-facing pillar: Add a dedicated page detailing a Great Books framework, sample readings, and a public commitment to “Great Conversation” as a curricular spine, complemented by explicit references to primary sources and canonical texts.
- Publicly document a formal Socratic-seminar plan across middle- and upper-grade levels: Include teacher training notes, exemplar rubrics, and sample seminar units to demonstrate sustained Socratic pedagogy in practice.
- Publish a formal “Living Curriculum” plan for Faculty (Element 5): Provide faculty job descriptions, teacher-formation protocols, and exemplar stories of teachers modeling classical virtues and serving as living exemplars in the classroom.

- Expand explicit evidence of a Seven Liberal Arts framework (Trivium/Quadrivium) within publicly accessible materials: Include a curriculum map that shows Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric progression, Latin/-Greek study expectations, and the integration of the Quadrivium in secondary grades.
- Increase explicit signaling of philosophical integration and Great Books (Element 3) through sample units and core texts to reinforce the classical identity beyond general “liberal arts” framing.
- Strengthen documentation of parent formation and community formation (Element 6) with ongoing book studies, parent-education events, and observable co-teaching activities.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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